

Children's Drawing Interpretation Guide

Compiled from the shared psychologist handout plus additional drawing-interpretation heuristics discussed earlier. These are not diagnostic rules; many are speculative or weakly supported, and children's age, context, and the child's own explanation matter greatly.

How to use the guide

General principle	What it means	Strength
Single drawing	Can suggest a possibility, but cannot diagnose depression, abuse, anxiety, or personality.	Speculative
Patterns across drawings	Repeated themes over time are more informative than one picture.	More useful
Child's explanation	Always ask what the drawing means to the child.	Very useful
Age and skill	Development, motor skill, and cultural style can change the drawing a lot.	Essential context

Eyes and face

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Wide eyes	Often interpreted as openness or alertness; in some emotion-drawing work, wide eyes can also fit fear/surprise.	Weak / mixed	Children's facial-expression drawings research; general projective tradition.
Strict, narrowed, or intense eyes	May be read as anger, tension, suspicion, or defensiveness.	Weak / mixed	General emotion-symbol heuristics.
Closed eyes	Sometimes interpreted as avoidance, shutting out the world, or refusing to look inward.	Speculative	No strong standard reference found.
Eyes with little detail or missing eyes	May suggest withdrawal, avoidance, low interest in contact, or simply limited drawing skill.	Weak / mixed	Projective drawing heuristics; developmental factors important.
Face expression	Smiling can suggest positive tone; sad, tense, or frightened faces can suggest distress.	Moderate for basic emotion only	Children do encode emotions in faces, but not as a diagnosis test.

Animals

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Tiger or wolf	Often informally linked with anger, threat, or aggression.	Speculative	No fixed universal rule found.
Fox	Sometimes informally linked with sneakiness or cunning.	Speculative	No fixed universal rule found.
Squirrel	Sometimes linked with need for protection, nervous energy, or seeking care.	Speculative	No fixed universal rule found.
Lion	Sometimes linked with dominance, pride, strength, or superiority.	Speculative	No fixed universal rule found.
Animal choice in general	Can reflect interests, story play, fear, identification, or a projective theme.	Weak / mixed	Animal-drawing tests and apperception traditions.

Geometric and symbolic shapes

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Geometric shapes preferred	Sometimes interpreted as planning, control, persistence, or stubbornness.	Speculative	Projective tradition, weak support.
Stars	Sometimes read as wanting attention, admiration, or visibility.	Speculative	No strong standard reference found.
Circles	Sometimes associated with unity, wholeness, or the need for closeness; in your handout, loneliness and need for support.	Speculative	Common heuristic, not standardized.
Flowers, sun, clouds	May be read as optimism, imagination, or positive mood when used in a dreamy context.	Speculative	No fixed rule; depends heavily on context.

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Hearts	Usually reflect affection, love, romance, or social warmth in a cultural sense.	Weak / common-sense	Symbolic meaning is culturally obvious, not psychometric.

Animals and objects with stories

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Transportation drawings	May suggest travel interest, movement, adventure, or a social/playful orientation.	Speculative	No strong literature basis found.
House	Sometimes discussed as family life, safety, privacy, or emotional openness, but not a reliable standalone test.	Weak / mixed	Projective drawing traditions.
Tree	Sometimes used to think about stability, growth, roots, or vulnerability.	Weak / mixed	Projective tree-drawing traditions.
Repeated monsters, danger, injury themes	May indicate fear, distress, or preoccupation with threat; needs careful follow-up.	Suggestive only	Trauma-informed assessment principles.

Size and page use

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Very large drawing / fills the page	Sometimes linked with expansiveness, strong energy, or self-assertion; your handout links it to high self-esteem.	Weak / mixed	Page occupation is a common projective heuristic.
Moderate drawing size (~half page)	Sometimes read as balance or mixed approach; your handout says open at times and introverted at times.	Speculative	No standardized cutoff.
Very small drawing	May suggest insecurity, withdrawal, fear, or low confidence; could also reflect carefulness or skill limits.	Weak / mixed	Size is a common but nonspecific cue.
Uses only a small part of the page	May suggest caution, uncertainty, or low confidence.	Weak / mixed	Projective interpretation.

Placement on the page

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Top of page	Sometimes read as fantasy, dreaming, ambition, or being less grounded in current reality.	Weak / mixed	Projective page-position heuristics.
Left side	Sometimes linked to introversion, past orientation, or dependence.	Speculative	No strong standard rule found.
Right side	Sometimes linked to extroversion, future orientation, or outward movement.	Speculative	No strong standard rule found.
Centering	Often read as balance, security, or comfort.	Speculative	Common heuristic.

Line quality and pressure

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Heavy pressure	May suggest tension, force, anger, or high energy.	Weak / mixed	Not specific to emotion; can reflect motor style.
Light pressure	May suggest hesitation, shyness, low energy, or delicacy.	Weak / mixed	Not specific to emotion.
Shaky or broken lines	May suggest anxiety, uncertainty, distress, or motor difficulty.	Weak / mixed	Needs comparison with age and motor skills.
Zigzag lines	Sometimes read as agitation, violence, unpredictability, or conflict.	Weak / mixed	Older projective and graphological traditions.
Over-erasing / frequent corrections	May suggest perfectionism, anxiety, frustration, or uncertainty.	Weak / mixed	Also common in normal development.

Missing or altered details

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Missing hands	Sometimes interpreted as difficulty acting, social difficulty, or avoidance.	Weak / mixed	Can be developmental.
Missing mouth	Sometimes linked with difficulty expressing emotion or communication issues.	Weak / mixed	Not specific.
Missing eyes	May suggest avoidance or emotional withdrawal.	Weak / mixed	Not specific.
Exaggerated body parts	Huge hands, teeth, eyes, etc. may suggest aggression, fear, or hypervigilance.	Weak / mixed	Very tentative.

Repeated themes

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Repeated monsters or danger scenes	May reflect a recurring fear or preoccupation.	Suggestive only	Best used with interview.
Repeated family conflict scenes	May indicate tension, perceived conflict, or concern in the home.	Suggestive only	Context is essential.
Repeated isolation themes	May point to loneliness or withdrawal.	Suggestive only	Not diagnostic.

Mood or concern flags sometimes discussed

Feature	Possible interpretation	Evidence level	Notes / literature
Dark colors, sad faces, isolation	Sometimes flagged as possible sadness, low mood, or distress.	Suggestive only	Color evidence is mixed; not diagnostic.
Refusal to draw figures	May suggest distress, resistance, perfectionism, or lack of task engagement.	Suggestive only	Can have many causes.
Excessive detail or fixation	May suggest anxiety, obsession with parts of the task, or strong interest.	Suggestive only	Not specific.
Neglect of background	May reflect focus on the main subject, limited time, or developmental style.	Weak / mixed	Not a pathology sign by itself.

Bottom line

Use these rules only as hypotheses. The most defensible reading comes from combining the drawing with the child's age, the drawing process, repeated patterns over time, and the child's own explanation. No single item here should be treated as proof of depression, abuse, anxiety, or personality type.